

Your Autistic Primary-School Child

For parents & family carers — understanding and supporting an autistic primary-school child (roughly ages 6–11).

The one idea

Autism, through **monotropism**, means your child's attention locks into a few deep, intense "tunnels." That tunnel is their engine — for joy, calm, skill and identity. The biggest gift you can give is an environment that works *with* their attention, not against it: predictable routines, protected interests, lower sensory load, and time to recover from the effort of holding it together at school.

What you may see — and what's really going on

You may see...	What's often happening
Intense focus on one topic, sometimes for years	A passion that brings joy, calm and learning — not an "obsession" to limit
"Fine at school," meltdown or shutdown the moment they're home	Home is the safe place where the day's mask finally drops — a sign of trust and exhaustion
Won't hear you; "ignores" hunger, thirst, the toilet	When absorbed, things outside the tunnel genuinely don't register
Slow to start, stop or switch; meltdowns at transitions	Autistic inertia — changing track costs real energy
Strong reactions to sounds, lights, clothes, food	Sensory differences: a stimulus <i>in</i> the tunnel is felt intensely; one <i>out</i> may not register

Try this

- **Protect and use the interest.** Build maths, reading and connection *through* it; never "wean" a healthy passion. Join it sometimes — sitting alongside with genuine curiosity is powerful.
- **Make the day predictable** — steady routines for mornings, after school, meals and bedtime — and give warnings before every transition ("10 minutes... 2 minutes...").
- **Lower the sensory load** at home: a quiet corner, dimmable light, headphones for noisy places, comfortable/seamless clothes.
- **Reduce demands on hard days.** If they held it together at school, expect a crash afterwards — build in calm, interest-led recovery time.
- **Have a meltdown/shutdown plan:** stay calm, lower the load (quiet, dim, fewer people), don't reason or judge in the

moment, give time, keep everyone safe.

Avoid this

- Treating the interest as a problem to manage, or the meltdown as naughtiness.
- Forcing eye contact, stillness or extra demands when they're already depleted.
- Piling on after-school activities and social plans — rest is a need, not laziness.

When to get more support

A sudden drop in skills usually signals **overwhelm/burnout**, not lost ability — respond by reducing demands and restoring rest and interests. Advocate at school (SENCO/SEND, a quiet space, interest-led learning). Watch for **anxiety and bullying**. Seek autism-led family support and a positively-framed understanding of autism for siblings.

If your child is a girl

Girls camouflage heavily and are often missed — the quiet, “anxious perfectionist” may be an exhausted autistic child. Trust your instincts and push for assessment if school sees only a compliant surface.

About this guide

*AI-assisted, derived from this project's research drafts — **Growing Up Monotropic** (Part 1), the **Family guide** (Part 3) and the **Monotropism** brief. Uses identity-first language. **Informational — not medical advice or a diagnostic tool**. You know your child best; fit this to them.*

Key sources. Murray, Lesser & Lawson (2005); Murray, F. (2018/2023; 2022, routines); Dwyer (2025); Raymaker et al. (2020); Reframing Autism (2023); Leicestershire Partnership NHS Trust (Autism Space, meltdowns/shutdowns). Full citations are in the source drafts.